

## **MIG-14**

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

### **Interviewee Profile**

Interview code: MIG-14

Age: 36

Gender: Male

Country of origin: Tibet

Host country: Switzerland

Years in host country: 11

Occupation: Cultural Center Coordinator

### **Interview**

#### **Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?**

A: I came to Switzerland eleven years ago as a Tibetan refugee, part of a diaspora community that fled the Chinese occupation of our homeland in search of the freedom to live as who we are. Switzerland has historically welcomed Tibetans, and it hosts one of the largest Tibetan communities in all of Europe, which made it a natural destination where I would not be entirely alone or without support. Seeking the freedom to practise our culture, our language, and our religion openly, freedoms that were suppressed at home, I found refuge here in this mountainous country whose landscape, strangely and movingly, reminded me of the Tibet I had lost. Arriving among an established community of my own people eased what would otherwise have been an overwhelming transition into an entirely foreign world.

#### **Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?**

A: Inclusion means being able to preserve and openly share my Tibetan culture while also being accepted as a genuine part of Swiss society, so that I am not forced to choose between the two. It shows itself when Swiss people show genuine, respectful interest in our heritage and our political struggle rather than mere curiosity, and when my community is seen as contributing positively to the country's diversity and cultural richness rather than as an isolated enclave. Belonging, for me, means having both a cultural home, the living community of Tibetans in exile, and a national home, Switzerland itself, and feeling that I am a full and valued member of each without one negating or diminishing the other in any way.

#### **Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?**

A: Compared to many other migrant groups, Tibetans face relatively less xenophobia here, partly because of a widespread sympathy for our political cause and the injustice of the occupation, and partly because of our reputation as a peaceful, non-threatening community, which works in our favour. However, we do still encounter the more general suspicion that many Swiss feel toward foreigners, and there are subtle assumptions and occasional instances of discrimination that remind us we are not quite regarded as belonging. Being visibly Asian in a predominantly white society means that I am

sometimes treated as perpetually foreign, as a permanent outsider, no matter how long I have lived here or how well I have integrated into the local life.

**Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?**

A: The main challenges were the profound cultural and linguistic differences, as Swiss German is genuinely difficult to master and the culture is notably reserved and private, which made forming connections slow and sometimes discouraging. Beyond the practical adjustments, there is the ongoing and deeply felt struggle of preserving our Tibetan identity in exile, especially for the younger generation who are growing up far from the homeland and are pulled strongly toward assimilation. And underlying everything is the particular pain of statelessness, of belonging to a people who have lost their country to occupation, a wound of dispossession and exile that never fully heals and that colours the entire experience of building a life in a foreign land.

**Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?**

A: I work at a Tibetan cultural centre, which is deeply and genuinely fulfilling, surrounded daily by my own community and by Swiss supporters who believe in our cause and value our culture. The environment is warm, purposeful, and mission-driven, and it gives real meaning to my days. Beyond the centre itself, my interactions with Swiss institutions and with Swiss people have generally been respectful and correct, and I have managed over the years to build meaningful and lasting relationships with locals who appreciate Tibetan culture and history and who have become genuine friends. Having found work that aligns so closely with my values and my sense of who I am has been a great fortune.

**Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?**

A: Preserving my Tibetan identity is not just important to me but is genuinely central to my life and my work; I am deeply and actively committed to our language, our Buddhism, and our traditions, and especially to passing all of these faithfully to the next generation growing up in exile, who might otherwise lose them entirely. At the same time, I have integrated meaningfully into Swiss society, learning the language, understanding and respecting the local customs, and participating in the life of the country. I embody, I suppose, the particular dual existence of the exile, rooted with my whole heart in a homeland that I cannot return to, while building a real and committed life in the country that gave me refuge.

**Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?**

A: Media coverage of Tibet tends to focus almost entirely on the political conflict with China, which does generate valuable international sympathy for our situation, but which also has the effect of reducing us, in the public imagination, to a cause or a political issue rather than a living, breathing culture and people. Tibetans as individuals building ordinary lives in exile, with our families, our work, our joys and struggles, are far less visible and are rarely portrayed. I would genuinely wish for coverage that shows our vibrant, evolving, and resilient community as it actually is, not merely our tragic and unresolved political situation, so that people might come to know us as a people and not only as a headline.

**Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?**

A: The Swiss support for Tibetan refugees has historically been good and relatively generous, with community organisations and integration assistance that helped many of us find our footing over the decades. Our own well-established community also provides very strong internal support, a network of mutual aid and cultural continuity that has been invaluable. Switzerland's specific approach to our community has been relatively welcoming compared to how some other migrant groups are treated, which I recognise as a real privilege. That said, the general support available for immigrant integration across the board could always be more robust and more attuned to the diverse and particular needs of different communities and their different circumstances.

**Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?**

A: The younger Tibetan generation, those born here in Switzerland, are fully Swiss in a great many ways, in language, in outlook, in cultural fluency, which creates in me a complicated mixture of pride at their belonging and genuine concern about the potential loss of our distinct culture and identity over time. I work hard, through the cultural centre and personally, to keep them connected to our language, our religion, and our traditions. They face the particular and poignant challenge of honouring and identifying with a homeland they have never actually seen with their own eyes, while simultaneously belonging to Switzerland, and navigating that complex dual identity is something I try to help them do with pride rather than confusion.

**Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?**

A: To reduce xenophobia, education about different cultures and about the specific circumstances that drive refugees from their homes is genuinely key, because understanding breeds acceptance. The Tibetan experience itself demonstrates something important: that when a host society comes to understand and sympathise with migrants' stories and struggles, acceptance grows more readily. Cultural exchange, in which local people can experience our traditions, our art, our food, and our spirituality firsthand rather than at a distance, builds the kind of mutual respect and understanding that reliably dissolves prejudice over time. Direct human and cultural contact, I firmly believe, achieves far more than abstract appeals ever could on their own.

**Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?**

A: I hope to strengthen and expand our cultural centre and to ensure that the next generation of Tibetans maintains and cherishes our heritage in exile, so that our culture survives and even flourishes far from its homeland. I dream, as every Tibetan does in their heart, of a free Tibet to which we could one day return, though I do not know if I will see it in my lifetime. Until that distant day, I want to continue building bridges between the Tibetan and Swiss communities, enriching both through genuine cultural exchange and mutual understanding, and demonstrating that a displaced people can contribute meaningfully to the society that shelters them.

**Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?**

A: My advice to fellow refugees is to hold onto your cultural identity fiercely and deliberately, because in a foreign land it is your anchor, your source of meaning and continuity, and it can be lost so easily if you do not actively tend it. At the same time, engage sincerely with and contribute genuinely to your host society, because integration and cultural preservation are not opposites but can and must go

together. Build strong community bonds for the mutual support that will sustain you through hard times. Educate others about your story and your people, because understanding truly does breed acceptance. And, through everything, never lose hope for your homeland, however distant its freedom may seem.